



Taj Mahal

An icon of India, a symbol of love and a monument to the wealth and power of the Mughal Empire

The Taj Mahal in Agra was built in the 17th century by Mughal emperor Shah Jahan (1592–1666). The white marble edifice was to be a mausoleum for his favorite wife, Mumtaz Mahal, who died in childbirth in 1631. The grief-stricken emperor ordered work to begin in the same year, but it took 22 years to complete, employing more than 20,000 workers—including masons and craftsmen from Persia, the Ottoman Empire, and Europe—and over 1,000 elephants.

Lavish decoration

The complex of buildings sits within a walled rectangle. At the south end are the entry gates, forecourt, and former bazaar; in the middle are the gardens; and at the north is the mausoleum itself, which stands on a 22-ft- (6.5-m-) high platform, with a 137-ft- (42-m-) high minaret at each corner. It is flanked to the east by a mosque and to the west by the *mehmankhana* (guest house), both built in red sandstone. The mausoleum was built from milky marble from Makrana in Rajasthan and appears to change color from pink to white to gold depending on the time of day. It is exquisitely carved and decorated with 28 different types of gems, such as turquoise from Tibet and jade from China.



△ MINARET FINIAL

The four minarets tilt slightly outward to avoid damaging the mausoleum should they collapse.

Famed Indian poet
Rabindranath Tagore
called the **Taj Majal**
“a **tear of marble ...**
on the cheek of time”



SYMMETRICAL DESIGN

The Taj Mahal complex is a work of perfect symmetry, broken only by the tombs of Mumtaz Mahal and Shah Jahan. The mausoleum is 187 ft (57 m) high—from the platform to the top of the dome—and is just as wide. Its layout is based on the *Hasht-bihisht* (eight paradises) plan often used by the Mughals. The four *iwans* (ceremonial halls) lead through decorated rooms to four octagonal chambers and a central, domed chamber.

KEY

- Iwan
- Octagonal chamber
- Central chamber

